afternoon, the story of what had happened—or, at least, bits of it—had got out to the press. I walked out of the house in Alderley Edge the following morning, with my hair pulled back to stop it falling against the cut over my eye and, within a couple of minutes, someone had taken the photo that was all over Monday's papers. Along with all the other emotions I was trying to get to grips with, I felt like Exhibit A.

It's bad enough having a dispute with your boss. It makes setting things straight all the harder when it seems like millions of people are looking over your shoulder, waiting to see what's going to happen, speculating about what might before it does. For a couple of days, at least, when I didn't feel like I was wandering around in a daze—how and why had things between me and the boss come to this—I was still seething about what he'd done in that dressing room, accident or not. Even though he'd said sorry straight afterwards, now this thing was in the public eye, I really believed the boss's apology should be made public too. I certainly didn't think it was up to me to make the first move.

Outside Old Trafford, the whole thing became this huge issue. In a way, everybody else saying what they had to say, whether they really knew or understood what had happened, made me concentrate harder on seeing the incident for what it was. We'd had a big argument, me and the manager. I'd said things I shouldn't have. He'd reacted. Badly.

And now I had a little cut over one eye. The tension of the past few months seemed to explode in those few moments. Only the boss could tell you what he'd been feeling but I knew—and he'd said so straight away—that he hadn't meant that boot to hit me, however angry he was. That much of it was a fluke. I thought things through. United had a huge game midweek against Juventus in the Champions League and I didn't want a personal problem between me and the boss to get in the way of our preparations.

I realized that, whatever the boss said or did, I could soften the situation ahead of the game on the Wednesday night at Old Trafford. It felt like the right thing to do: for me, for my team-mates and the club. I released a statement saying that what had happened had been an accident; that it was behind us now and that all that mattered was focusing on beating Juventus. Which we went on to do, 2–1. The manager made a point, after the game, of saying publicly that I'd played particularly well. I appreciated that. And the next time we sat down to talk, it was about soccer. There wasn't a big meeting or anything. We watched the video of the Arsenal defeat. The boss pointed out where he thought I'd been caught out of position for the second goal but